

disable most sharing settings. Selecting the “My Friends Only” box in Myspace will lock out strangers from viewing your profile.

A trick used to gain information involves someone creating a new account with your friend’s name and a few general details. Then they send a friend request to you, stating they’ve created a new account (for some reason or another). In this case, confirm with your friend personally or over his old account whether the new account is real or not.

## 2.5 Using secure passwords

Passwords are the keys to access personal information stored in your computer. This means they are the one barrier between your data being safe and sound to having your entire system compromised.

The strongest passwords are those that are the longest. Most passwords should at least be 8 characters in length but those with 14 or more characters are the best. Combine letters, numbers and symbols culled from the entire keyboard. Your password will be much stronger if you choose from all symbols on the keyboard, including punctuation marks not on the upper row of the keyboard and even symbols unique to your own language. Substitute letters with similar looking numbers (for example, “A” with “4”) and also mix uppercase and lowercase letters. Throw some misspellings in there as well.

The greater variety of characters in your password, the harder it is to guess. If you cannot create a password that contains symbols, you need to make it considerably longer to get the same degree of protection. An ideal password is one that combines both length and different characters. Finally, use words and phrases that are easy for you to remember but difficult for others to guess.

The various don’ts to follow when making a strong password are:

- Avoid sequences or repeated characters. “12345678,” “222222,” “abcdefg,” or adjacent letters on your keyboard do not help make secure passwords.
- Avoid using only look-alike substitutions of numbers or symbols. Criminals and other malicious users who know enough to try and crack your password will not be fooled by common look-alike replacements, such as to